

COMING UP
Vir Das will perform at venues like Carnegie Hall, The Kennedy Center and Dubai Opera

As he adds new countries to his tour—Brazil and Japan—his set essentially stays the same. Das begins with a few minutes of local content to break the ice. "It's very like 'I landed yesterday and here are three things I noticed' just to acknowledge that we are both in the same city," he says. "It's never good. You have to get to the nuanced, deeply thought-out lines pretty quick." Be it Norway or Tokyo, Das will make you navigate the idiosyncrasies of life in Noida and Goa. "Ironically, it's become more important to do an authentic Indian story because that's the perspective audiences are coming for," he says.

Das provides that and is also unafraid to show audiences the mirror. "For the longest time, we were the punch line. They used our accent for a laugh," says Das. "That punch line is now talking about your country and not in a flattering way. I am not doing the 'I am so happy to be here routine' as immigrant comics are used to doing." Audiences are now more receptive to his observations, musings and vulnerabilities, but there will always be those who call him out with the "This is not comedy" jibe. "As long as you try to innovate with an art form and see where it can go, there's backlash," he says, citing his admiration for Hannah Gadsby's *Nanette*. And the ability to innovate only comes when you're self-assured in your form and voice. "All I know is that I feel comfortable with being myself anywhere," says Das.

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Going by the response of Indian audiences to 'Mind Fool', it appears that the bad blood, if any, has been set aside. Das has been working on the show for months now, testing it in smaller venues and rewriting the material. Will the upcoming tour also culminate in a special like the others? Das quickly responds in the negative. "A special takes the life out of me," he says. "It took 120 shows to get it to the point of *Landing*." There's also paucity of time as Das dabbles in acting with a string of projects including the Amazon Prime series *Call Me Bae*, another web series with Applause and a return to Hindi films with an action comedy. Another one takes him to Hollywood.

Das doesn't inadvertently want to become the headline anymore. He is just happy to be doing what he knows best—making people laugh. But is it easy to do comedy now? "The stakes for the country are much higher than for comedians," he says. "Comedians are relegated to our rightful place of importance, which is not very important at all. Any day a comedian is in the news is not a good day for news." ■

Suhani Singh

MUSIC FESTIVAL CALENDAR

- **Outback,** *Leh, Sep. 16-17, 2023*
- **Ziro Festival of Music,** *Ziro Valley, Sep. 28-Oct. 1, 2023*
- **GAIA Festival,** *Kullu, Sep. 30-Oct. 1, 2023*
- **Mahindra Independence Rock,** *Mumbai, Nov. 4-5, 2023*
- **Palm Tree Music Festival,** *Mumbai, Nov. 4-5, 2023*
- **SPXCEJXM,** *Bengaluru, Mumbai, Nov. 4-5, 2023*
- **DGTL India,** *Bengaluru, Mumbai Nov. 17-18 and Nov. 18-19, 2023*
- **Bacardi NH7 Weekender,** *Pune, Dec. 1-3, 2023*
- **Echoes of Earth,** *Bengaluru, Dec. 2-3, 2023*
- **Magnetic Fields,** *Alsisar, Dec. 15-17, 2023*
- **Sunburn,** *Goa, Dec. 28-31, 2023*
- **Lollapalooza India,** *Mumbai, Jan. 27-28, 2024*
- **Mahindra Blues Festival,** *Mumbai, Feb. 10-11, 2024*
- **Bloomverse,** *Shillong, Feb. 24, 2024*

on Sunday, August 27, though those who attended the first edition can buy passes a couple of days ahead.

These are just a handful of names in a busy festival calendar. Others include imports such as the multi-city, electronic music celebrating **DGTL** and long-running favourites like the **Bacardi NH7 Weekender** in Pune and **Independence Rock** in Mumbai.

The first weekend of November will be particularly hectic in Mumbai as it will also witness the inaugural instalments of Norwegian DJ-producer Kygo's **Palm Tree Music Festival** in India and **SPXCEJXM**, a new multi-genre festival that will take place simultaneously in Bengaluru. It isn't just large cities that are drawing music fans. In addition to Ziro, held in Arunachal's Ziro Valley, there's the **GAIA Festival** in Kullu–which leans towards electronic music–and **Outback** in Leh–which claims to be the "world's highest motorable adventure and music festival"–both of which will return for a second round in September.

Among the factors that have led to the festival boom, according to Owen Roncon, Chief of Business, Live Entertainment, at BookMyShow, are the growth of streaming services that have not only made India one of the largest markets for several artists globally but also led to the discovery and rising popularity of diverse genres. "India is increasingly becoming a focus region for international performers [looking] to cater to large swathes of young fans here," says Roncon. ■

Amit Gurbaxani